

Teacher Guide

Heidi · Chapter 1: Going Up to the Alm-Uncle · Grade 3

Lesson Overview

Use this guide to introduce the chapter, support close reading, and prepare students for discussion and writing. This guide is designed for a 60-minute instructional period or two 30-minute sessions.

Measurable Objectives

- Students will be able to Identify and describe the main characters (Heidi, Deta, Grandfather [Alm-Uncle], Peter) using evidence from the text (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Define 6 key vocabulary words (avoid, consider, explore, journey, responsible, treasure) using context clues and apply them in sentences (L.3.4)
- Students will be able to Sequence the major events of Heidi's journey from Maienfeld up the mountain to Grandfather's hut and explain why each event is important (RL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Make inferences about character feelings and motivations based on their actions and dialogue, such as why Deta brings Heidi to Grandfather and why Heidi removes her heavy clothes on the mountain path (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Engage effectively in collaborative discussions by building on others' ideas, asking clarifying questions, and providing text evidence to support thinking (SL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences (W.3.3)

Standards

Reading Literature

- **RL.3.1** — Ask and answer questions to demonstrate understanding of a text, referring explicitly to the text as the basis for the answers.
- **RL.3.3** — Describe characters in a story (e.g., their traits, motivations, or feelings) and explain how their actions contribute to the sequence of events.

Writing

- **W.3.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences.
- **W.3.4** — With guidance and support from adults, produce writing in which the development and organization are appropriate to task and purpose.

Language

- **L.3.4** — Determine or clarify the meaning of unknown and multiple-meaning word and phrases based on grade 3 reading and content, choosing flexibly from a range of strategies.

Speaking and Listening

- **SL.3.1** — Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions (one-on-one, in groups, and teacher-led) with diverse partners on grade 3 topics and texts, building on others' ideas and expressing their own clearly.

Materials Needed

- Heidi, by Johanna Spyri (Classic Books for All edition), Chapter 1, for each student.
- Classic Books for All Heidi Student Workbook.
- Pencil and notebook.
- Whiteboard and markers.
- Optional: Drawing paper and colored pencils.

Get Ready to Read

Quick-write prompt

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Implementation

- Ask students to think about a time they went somewhere new for the first time.
- Display or read aloud this prompt: 'Think about a time you went somewhere new. How did you feel? Write two or three sentences.'
- Give students 2–3 quiet writing minutes to respond in their journals or on paper.
- Invite students to share with their neighbor what they wrote.
- Tell students that in this chapter, a little girl named Heidi is taken to a new place for the very first time, and they will find out how she feels about it.

Connection tip: Connecting a new reading to students' own experiences with unfamiliar places helps them understand Heidi's feelings as she arrives at her grandfather's mountain home.

Words to Know Mini-Lesson

Mini-lesson

1. avoid (*page 4*)
2. consider (*page 3*)
3. explore (*page 12*)
4. journey (*page 7*)
5. responsible (*page 5*)
6. treasure (*page 11*)

Activities

Introduce words with context

- Write each word on the board.
- Read the sentence from the book containing the word.
- Think-aloud: "What clues help me understand this word?"
- Example for *explore*: "It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner." (p. 12) — Look at the words around it. Heidi is excited and it is an adventure. What do you do when you are excited about a new place? That helps you figure out what explore means.

Partner practice

- Assign partners.
- Each pair gets two to three vocabulary words.
- Partners find the word in the text and discuss what it might mean.
- Use sentence: "I think _____ means _____ because the text says _____."

Quick check

- Call on pairs to share definitions.
- Confirm or clarify meanings.
- Post vocabulary words on Word Wall.

Guided Reading with Pause Points

Section 1: pages 1–3

Read from In the cozy little town of Maienfeld, there's a pretty, green path that leads up to the tall mountains. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What is the little girl wearing on the hot summer morning, and how does it make walking hard for her?
2. The word 'journey' means a trip from one place to another. Find the sentence in this section that tells you Deta and Heidi are on a journey. Where are they going?
3. Heidi says she is 'hot' but not tired. What does this tell you about how she feels about the climb?

Section 2: pages 3–5

Read from Where are you taking the child, Deta? ...

Pause and ask:

1. Why is Deta taking Heidi to live with Alm-Uncle?
2. The word 'avoid' means to stay away from someone on purpose. Why do the people in the village avoid Alm-Uncle?
3. Barbara says Deta 'must be out of your mind to consider' taking Heidi to Alm-Uncle. What does this tell you about what Barbara thinks of Alm-Uncle?

Section 3: pages 5–8

Read from Tobias trained as a carpenter in a place called Mels. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What happened to Tobias and Adelheid, and what did the old man do after they died?
2. The word 'responsible' means doing what you are supposed to do and making good choices. How does the story show that Tobias was responsible, unlike his father?
3. Peter spends most of his day alone with goats on the mountain. How do you think that makes him feel? Use words from the chapter to help explain your answer.

Section 4: pages 8–11

Read from Suddenly, Heidi sat down and quickly took off her shoes and socks. ...

Pause and ask:

1. Why did Heidi take off her clothes and shoes while climbing the mountain?
2. The word 'treasure' means something that is very valuable to you. Why was the five-penny coin a treasure to Peter?
3. Peter did not want to go back down the mountain to get Heidi's clothes. What made him change his mind and go quickly?

Section 5: pages 11–13

Read from After almost an hour, they reached Heidi's grandfather's hut. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What does Heidi do when she reaches her grandfather's hut for the first time?
2. The word 'explore' means to look around a new place to find out what is there. Find the sentence that shows Heidi wants to explore. What does this tell you about how Heidi feels about being at the hut?
3. Grandfather asks gruff questions and seems upset when Deta brings Heidi. But the story also says 'his face softening into a smile.' What do you think Grandfather really feels when he sees Heidi?

Read-aloud tip: Before reading each new section, point to the opening phrase and ask students to listen for what happens next.

Think About the Story — Answers + Inferential Thinking

Inferential Thinking

- Why do you think Deta dressed Heidi in so many layers of clothing even though it was a hot summer day?
- Why do you think the old man's face softened into a smile when Heidi called out to him?
- Why do you think Peter ran off immediately when Grandfather told him to take the goats away?
- Why do you think Heidi took off her extra clothes and shoes without asking Deta first?
- Why do you think everyone in the village was afraid of Alm-Uncle even though he was their neighbor?

Tiered Discussion Prompts

Literal: Who is taking Heidi up the mountain at the beginning of the story? | Where is Deta going when she leaves Heidi with her grandfather? | What does Heidi take off while climbing the mountain with Peter and the goats? | What does Deta offer Peter so he will go back down the hill to fetch Heidi's clothes?

Inference: Why do you think Deta feels it is the grandfather's turn to take care of Heidi? | What clues in the story tell you that the grandfather lives a lonely life on the mountain? | Why do you think Heidi felt much more comfortable after taking off her extra clothes? | What do you think the grandfather was feeling when he watched the children climb up to his hut?

Analysis: How does Barbara's reaction to Deta's plan show us how the villagers feel about Alm-Uncle? | Why do you think the author tells us the story of Alm-Uncle's past? What does it help us understand about him? | How is Heidi's behavior on the mountain different from what Deta expects of her? What does this tell us about Heidi's character? | How do the details about Peter's daily life help us understand what Heidi's new life on the mountain might be like?

Evaluation: Do you think Deta made the right choice leaving Heidi with her grandfather? Why or why not? | Do you think Alm-Uncle will be a good caretaker for Heidi? Use details from the story to support your answer. | Was it fair of Deta to leave Heidi without giving the grandfather any warning or choice? Explain your thinking. | If you were Heidi, how would you feel about moving in with a grandfather you had never really met? Would you feel the same way Heidi seems to feel, or differently?

Analytical Thinking

- The author gives us two very different pictures of Alm-Uncle — the scary old man the villagers gossip about, and the man whose face softens into a smile when he sees Heidi. Why do you think the author shows us both sides? What might this tell us about what will happen next in the story?
- Deta tells Barbara the story of Alm-Uncle's past so that Barbara (and the reader) can understand why he lives alone. Think about the choices Alm-Uncle made when he was young. How might those choices explain why he acts the way he does now?
- Heidi asks Peter lots of questions about the goats and seems excited about everything she sees. What do these details tell us about the kind of person Heidi is, and how might her personality affect her grandfather's lonely life on the mountain?

Personal Connection

- Have you ever had to go somewhere new where you did not know anyone, like a new school or a relative's home? How did it feel? How is that like or unlike what Heidi is going through?
- Heidi took off her heavy clothes because she was uncomfortable, even though she knew Deta might not like it. Have you ever made a choice to do what felt right for you, even when you were not sure a grown-up would approve? What happened?
- Peter spends most of his day alone with the goats on the mountain. Do you think you would enjoy that kind of quiet, outdoor life, or would you miss being around other people? What does your answer tell you about yourself?

Answer Key

Reading Between the Lines — Answers

Dig Deeper — Answers

Multiple Choice — Answers

Evidence from the Story — Sample Answers

Character Chart — Answer Key

Character Description What This Shows Quote Page

Draw It! — Suggested Details

- Heidi's grandfather sits on a wooden bench beside his mountain hut, holding a pipe between his teeth and resting both hands on his knees.
- Three tall old fir trees rise up behind the hut, and a sheer rock face stands beyond them.
- The hut sits at the top of a rocky, windy patch of ground with a wide view of the green valley far below.
- Goats wander around the hut, nibbling on the grass in the bright sunshine.
- Heidi, wearing only a light undershirt, bounces around the hut with rosy cheeks, eager to explore every corner.

Differentiated Supports

Struggling Readers

Before reading: Show students a simple drawing or picture of a mountain path and a small hut. Tell them: 'A little girl named Heidi is going to live with her grandfather on a big mountain. Let's find out what happens.' | Pre-teach six key words before reading: avoid, consider, explore, journey, responsible, treasure. Use the definitions in the workbook and act out each word with simple movements (e.g., walk away for 'avoid,' pretend to look around for 'explore'). | Read aloud the first paragraph together as a class so students know how the story sounds before reading on their own.

During reading: Pause after every two pages and ask one simple question students can point to in the text, such as: 'What is Heidi wearing?' or 'What does Heidi take off when she gets too hot?' | Provide a simple story map with four boxes labeled: Who, Where, What happened first, What happened next. Students fill in one box at a time as they read. | Allow students to read with a partner, taking turns one paragraph at a time, so no one reads alone for too long.

After reading: Ask students to draw one scene from the chapter and write one sentence about it using the sentence starter: 'In this chapter, Heidi ____.' | Use three simple comprehension questions students can answer by finding the sentence in the book: (1) What is the little girl's name? (2) Who is taking Heidi up the mountain? (3) Where will Heidi live? | Have students retell the chapter to a partner using three pictures: Heidi on the path, Heidi taking off her clothes, and Heidi meeting Grandfather.

English Language Learners

Before reading: Build background by showing pictures of a mountain, a goat, a hut, and a grandfather. Label each picture and say the word aloud together. | Introduce the six vocabulary words with both a picture and a simple sentence. For example, show a picture of someone walking away and say: 'Avoid means to stay away from something or someone.' | Preview the names in the chapter — Heidi, Deta, Barbara, Peter, Alm-Uncle — and practice saying them aloud together so students feel comfortable when they meet them in the text.

During reading: Provide a bilingual word list or picture glossary for the most important words in the chapter, such as: mountain, path, grandfather, goats, shawl, hut, bench. | Encourage students to circle any word they do not know and keep reading. After finishing the page, they can look at the picture on that page to help figure out the meaning. | Pair ELL students with a patient partner who can quietly explain what is happening in each scene.

After reading: Have students answer two simple questions in writing using sentence frames: 'Heidi is going to live with ____ because ____.' and 'When Heidi got hot, she ____.' | Ask students to draw Heidi and Grandfather meeting for the first time and label at least two things in their picture using words from the chapter. | Let students share one thing they liked or one thing they noticed about the chapter in their home language or in English — both are welcome.

Advanced Students

Before reading: Ask students to think about this question before reading: 'What makes someone a good caregiver for a child?' Have them write two or three sentences and then compare their ideas to what happens in the chapter. | Challenge students to predict: based only on the title 'Going Up to the Alm-Uncle,' what kind of character do they think the grandfather will be? Why? | Invite students to notice how the author introduces characters through what other people say about them rather than describing them directly. Ask them to look for examples as they read.

During reading: Ask students to track how other characters talk about Alm-Uncle and note whether what they say matches what actually happens when Heidi meets him at the end of the chapter. | Have students write one or two margin notes as they read: one place where they feel sympathy for a character and one place where they have a

question about a character's choices. | Challenge students to think about Deta's point of view versus Barbara's point of view about leaving Heidi with Grandfather. Whose argument do they find more convincing, and why?

After reading: Have students write a short paragraph from Deta's point of view defending her decision to leave Heidi with Grandfather, and then write one sentence from Grandfather's point of view responding to her. | Ask students to compare how the author builds the reader's image of Alm-Uncle through rumors versus how he actually behaves when Heidi arrives. What effect does this technique create? | Challenge students to find three details from the chapter that show Heidi's personality and explain in writing what those details tell us about who she is.

Common Student Questions

1. Why is Heidi wearing so many clothes if it is hot outside? (p. 9)

Deta did not want to carry extra clothes, so she dressed Heidi in her everyday clothes AND her Sunday clothes on top of each other. It was easier to put them all on Heidi than to carry them.

2. Why does Heidi take off her shoes and extra dresses on the mountain path? (p. 8)

Heidi was very hot and the heavy clothes made climbing hard. She saw Peter moving easily in light clothes and bare feet, so she took off her extra layers to feel more comfortable.

3. Why is Deta taking Heidi to live with her grandfather instead of keeping her? (p. 3)

Deta has been offered a new job far away in Frankfurt. She cannot take Heidi with her, so she decides it is time for Heidi's grandfather to help take care of her.

4. Why does everyone call the old man 'Alm-Uncle' if he is not really their uncle? (p. 5)

People in the village got used to calling him 'Uncle' as a nickname. When he moved to the mountain farm called the Alm, people added 'Alm' to the front, so the nickname became 'Alm-Uncle.'

5. Why does Peter not want to go back down the mountain to get Heidi's clothes? (p. 9)

Peter says he is already late. The walk down and back would take about half an hour, and he did not want to do the extra work. He only agreed when Deta offered him a coin.

6. Why does Grandfather seem grumpy when Deta brings Heidi to him? (p. 12)

Grandfather lives alone and does not talk to people. He is worried he will not know how to take care of a small child if she cries or misses her family.

7. Why does Peter run away quickly when Grandfather tells him to go bring the goats? (p. 12)

Grandfather gave Peter a stern, serious look. Peter was a little scared of the old man and was happy to leave quickly.

Creative Response

Common errors

No Specific Details From The Chapter

Some students write about Heidi in a general way without using details from the chapter. They say things like 'Heidi was excited' without pointing to anything specific that happened in the story. Good writing uses small, real details from the text to show what the character is thinking or feeling.

Weak example: Heidi was happy to be on the mountain. She liked being outside.

How to fix: Point students back to specific moments in the chapter. Ask: 'What did Heidi do that showed she was happy?' For example, students can write about Heidi taking off her shoes and heavy clothes so she could move like the goats, or about Heidi bouncing around and looking at everything when she reached the hut.

Breaking Character

Some students write things that Heidi would never say or do based on what we know about her in the chapter. Heidi is a curious, bold, and cheerful five-year-old who acts without worrying too much. Students sometimes make her sound afraid or shy, which does not match who she is in the story.

Weak example: Heidi was scared to talk to her grandfather. She hid behind Deta and would not come out.

How to fix: Remind students that in the chapter, Heidi walks right up to the old man and says 'Good evening, Grandfather!' She even stares at his long beard with curiosity. Ask: 'Does Heidi seem scared in the chapter?' Help students write a response that matches the brave and cheerful girl in the story.

Retelling The Whole Chapter Instead of Focusing on Heidi's Experience

Some students simply retell what already happened in the chapter instead of writing a creative response. They copy events from the story word for word or just list what Heidi did. A creative response asks students to imagine something new, like what Heidi might say, think, or do next.

Weak example: Heidi climbed up the mountain with Deta. Then she took off her shoes. Then she got to grandfather's hut.

How to fix: Tell students: 'We already read what happened. Now we want to know what YOU think Heidi might do or say next.' Help them think forward. For example: 'What might Heidi say to her grandfather the next morning?' or 'What might Heidi think when she sees the three big fir trees behind the hut?'

No Evidence From the Text

Some students make claims about Heidi without connecting their ideas to the chapter. They say things like 'Heidi would be very sad' without explaining why they think that based on the story. Good responses use what we read to support the ideas.

Weak example: Heidi would cry all night because she missed Deta.

How to fix: Ask students: 'What do we know about Heidi from the chapter that makes you think that?' Remind them that Heidi did not cry when Deta left. She was bouncing around and exploring. Help students base their writing on what Heidi actually said and did, like calling out cheerfully to her grandfather or playing with the goats.

Modern Language That Doesn't Fit The Story

Some students use very modern words or phrases that do not fit the world of the story. Heidi lives on a mountain in Switzerland long ago. She would not use words like 'okay,' 'cool,' 'awesome,' or 'totally.' This kind of language pulls the reader out of the story's setting.

Weak example: Heidi looked at the goats and said, 'Wow, these guys are so awesome! This place is totally cool!'

How to fix: Remind students that Heidi uses simple, old-fashioned speech in the chapter. She says things like 'Good evening, Grandfather' and 'I didn't need them.' Encourage students to use plain, simple sentences that

sound like the words in the book. Reading a line of dialogue from the chapter aloud can help students hear the right tone.

Exit Ticket

Prompt: Predict what will happen next chapter, and explain why using a detail from the text.

Success Criteria

- Makes a clear prediction about what will happen next
- Uses at least one detail from the text as evidence
- Explains the thinking using the word because

Example Responses

Strong: I think Grandfather will be grumpy but will let Heidi stay because Deta leaves before he can say no. The text says Deta told him, 'You'll figure it out,' and she seemed ready to go.

Developing: I think Heidi will stay with Grandfather. He seemed a little nice when he smiled at her.